(1) Where the money goes

Phase 1 · Prepare
code + dry run on sample
$0

→

Phase 2 · Full data in
clean, split, cluster
$0

→

Phase 3 · Pilot
4 models · 350 prompts
~$9–24

gate: you approve the budget

→

Phase 4 · Full build
5 models · 700 prompts
~$7–24

gate: judge–human ≥ 75%

→

Phase 5 · Gateway
rules, cache, router
$0

→

Phase 6 · Evaluate
locked test, report
~$1–2

Total
~$17–50
planned: $60

(2) Budget detail

Item	API calls	Estimate	Range on a $0–25 scale
Pilot · generation (4 models × 350 prompts)	1,400	~$3	
Pilot · judging (pointwise 1,400 + pairwise 2,100)	3,500	$6–21	
Full build · generation (4 models × 350 more, 5th model × 700)	2,100	~$3–4	
Full build · judging, pointwise / pairwise	2,100 / 3,500	$3–13 / $6–21	
Evaluate · production quality (optional), latency runs	300–600	$1–2	
Total	**~9,400–11,100**	**$17–50**	planned with buffer: **$60**

Bars: solid = low estimate, dashed = up to the high estimate. Judging is the biggest and most uncertain cost.

Rules: every call is cached, so re-runs cost $0. Pilot answers and grades are reused by the full build. All numbers are recomputed from the full data before any paid call.

(3) Cost per call (list-price estimates)

Model	Role	$ / 1M in · out	≈ $ per call
gemini-2.5-flash-lite	cheap	0.10 · 0.40	0.0002
deepseek-v4-flash	cheap	0.14 · 0.28	0.0003
gpt-4o-mini	cheap	0.15 · 0.60	0.0004
gemini-2.5-flash	medium	0.30 · 2.50	0.0009
claude-sonnet-4-6	strong · anchor	3.00 · 15.00	0.0075
Judge (gpt-5.x class)	grades answers	—	0.002–0.006

One call ≈ 1,640 input + 174 output tokens (sample average). No prompt-cache discount assumed, so real costs are likely lower. The strong anchor costs ~20–30× a cheap model.

(4) How calls are counted (spec §9)

N = models · N_val = 400 · N_te = 300 · J = 2 (pairwise order swap)

Generation = N × (N_val + N_te)
Judge, pointwise = N × (N_val + N_te)
Judge, pairwise = (N − 1) × (N_val + N_te) × J

Later: add a new model (no retraining)
pointwise: 2 × N_val = 800 calls ≈ $1–3 · pairwise: N_val × (1 + J) = 1,200 calls ≈ $1.5–5

Free forever after
remove a model · price change · new λ · re-clustering: $0

Blue: free · orange: paid API calls · green: future model additions · yellow: total